

Commonly misused words and expressions

Using *bored of* instead of *bored by* or *bored with*

- ✗ She was bored **of** studying.
- ✗ He was bored **of** the classes.
- ✓ She was bored **with** studying.
- ✓ He was bored **by** the classes.

Confusing *compared to* and *compared with*

Compared to should be used when asserting that two things are alike. In this sentence, Jess was like the best in the class.

- ✓ The teacher compared Jess **to** the best in the class.

Compared with should be used when comparing the similarities and differences between two things. In the sentence below, the teacher was considering how similar Jess was to the best in the class.

- ✓ The teacher compared Jess **with** the best in the class.

Using *different than* instead of *different from*

- ✗ The left side is different **than** the right side.
- ✓ The left side is different **from** the right side.

Using *like* as a conjunction instead of *as if* or *as though*

Like is correctly used as a preposition in the final example sentence; it should not be used as a conjunction.

- ✗ He acted **like** he didn't care.
- ✓ He acted **as though** he didn't care.
- ✓ It looks **like** a turtle.

Using *or* with *neither*

Either and *or* go together, and *neither* and *nor* go together.

- ✗ Use **neither** the left one **or** the right one.
- ✓ Use **either** the left one **or** the right one.
- ✓ Use **neither** the left one **nor** the right one.

Using *should of*, *would of*, and *could of* instead of *should have*, *would have*, and *should have*

Of is often wrongly used to mean *have* in spoken English.

- ✗ Steve **should of** stood up for himself.
- ✓ Steve **should have** stood up for himself.
- ✓ Steve **should've** stood up for himself.

Using *try and* and *go and* instead of *try to* and *go to*

The conjunction *and* is often wrongly used instead of the preposition *to* with the verbs *try* and *go*.

- ✗ We should **try and** change our flights.
- ✓ We should **try to** change our flights.
- ✗ I'll **go and** see the show.
- ✓ I'll **go to** see the show.

Using nouns as verbs

In spoken English, especially jargon, it is common for nouns to be used as verbs. This practice is best avoided.

- ✗ The fire will **impact** the environment.
- ✓ The fire will have **an impact** on the environment.

Rules for forming sentences

- A sentence must always contain a subject and a verb, start with a capital letter, and end with a period, question mark, or exclamation point. A sentence may also contain an object.
- The basic structure for a sentence to follow is subject–verb–object.
- Never join two main clauses using only a comma. Either separate the clauses into two separate sentences by using a period or a semicolon, or add a joining word such as *and* or *but* after the comma.
- Ensure that a sentence makes sense. If it doesn't make sense, one of the essential ingredients is probably missing, so the sentence is incomplete. For example, a subordinate clause does not make a complete sentence on its own; the main clause is also needed.
- Make sure that the subject and verb match. If the subject is singular, then the verb should be singular; if the subject is plural, then the verb should be plural.
- Use the active voice instead of the passive voice. The active voice is simpler, so the meaning is conveyed more clearly.
- Use positive sentence structure instead of negative sentence structure whenever possible in order to simplify sentences and make them easier to understand.
- Sentences should have a parallel structure. This means that the same patterns of words should be used to show that different parts of the sentence have equal importance.

- ✗ Darcy likes swimming, running, and to ride her bike.
- ✓ Darcy likes to swim, run, and ride her bike.